

George Washington (February 22, 1732 [[O.S. February 11, 1731](#)][\[a\]](#) – December 14, 1799) was a [Founding Father](#) and the first [president of the United States](#), serving from 1789 to 1797. As commander of the [Continental Army](#), Washington led [Patriot](#) forces to victory in the [American Revolutionary War](#) against the [British Empire](#). He is commonly known as the [Father of the Nation](#) for his role in bringing about [American independence](#).

Born in the [Colony of Virginia](#), Washington became the commander of the [Virginia Regiment](#) during the [French and Indian War](#) (1754–1763). He was later elected to the [Virginia House of Burgesses](#), and opposed the perceived oppression of the American colonists by the British Crown. When the American Revolutionary War against the British began in 1775, Washington was appointed [commander-in-chief of the Continental Army](#). He directed a poorly organized and equipped force against disciplined British troops. Washington and his army achieved an early victory at the [Siege of Boston](#) in March 1776 but were forced to [retreat from New York City](#) in November. Washington [crossed the Delaware River](#) and won the battles [of Trenton](#) in late 1776 and [of Princeton](#) in early 1777, then lost the battles [of Brandywine](#) and [of Germantown](#) later that year. He faced criticism of his command, low troop morale, and a lack of provisions for his forces as the war continued. Ultimately Washington led a combined French and American force to a decisive victory over the British at [Yorktown](#) in 1781. In the resulting [Treaty of Paris](#) in 1783, the British acknowledged the sovereign independence of the United States. Washington then served as president of the [Constitutional Convention](#) in 1787, which drafted the current [Constitution of the United States](#).

Washington was unanimously elected the first U.S. president by the [Electoral College](#) in 1788 and 1792. He implemented a strong, well-financed national government while remaining impartial in the fierce rivalry that emerged within his cabinet between [Thomas Jefferson](#) and [Alexander Hamilton](#). During the [French Revolution](#), he proclaimed [a policy of neutrality](#) while supporting the [Jay Treaty](#) with Britain. Washington set enduring precedents for the [office of president](#), including [republicanism](#), a [peaceful transfer of power](#), the use of the title "[Mr. President](#)", and the [two-term tradition](#). [His 1796 farewell address](#) became a preeminent statement on republicanism: Washington wrote about the importance of national unity and the dangers that regionalism, partisanship, and foreign influence pose to it. As a planter of [tobacco](#) and [wheat](#) at [Mount Vernon](#), [Washington owned many slaves](#). He began opposing slavery near the end of his life, and provided in his will for the eventual [manumission](#) of his slaves.

Washington's image is an icon of [American culture](#) and he [has been extensively memorialized](#); his namesakes include [the national capital](#) and the [State of Washington](#). In both popular and scholarly polls, he is consistently considered one of the greatest presidents in American history.